

who just need something basic yet functional. For such people i.e. those who cannot/will not spend more than Rs 8,000 on a cellphone, we present this test.

Cellphones up to Rs 4,000

The minnows in a sea of sharks

Basic cell phones may be far from flagships but they rule the volumes game. So while budget cellphones will not have features like WLAN, integrated GPS and a great camera, for every person who finds a high-end phone at least 20 more people buy an entry level handset. In fact, this segment is ultra competitive as peoples tastes change very fast. Phones like the iPhone are sought for the immeasurable sex appeal associated with the device; and a thousand reviews of the same bloom online. Demand for it remains more or less stable — people who want an iPhone



LG's RD 3600

will remain fans. But what about a Rs 3,000 device which is only solid in India and that too only with a Reliance CDMA connection? Details are sure to be scarce and reliable views and opinions about as rare as rain in a desert.

We tested a total of seven phones priced below the Rs 4,000 mark. Obviously most of these phones are CDMA handsets. CDMA is very prevalent with the lower-

end of the handset market. This is because most people go for a CDMA phone simply because Reliance and Tata (the two main CDMA service providers) provide very cheap call rates. Another factor is that the calls made within the same service providers' circle are usually free. Many people who already have a smartphone with a GSM SIM card therefore opt for a cheap CDMA handset just to make local calls, or send bulk SMSes or any similar usage scenario.

Five of the seven handsets were LG ones while Nokia and Samsung have a model each in this category.

Features

LG provided us with four models that obviously form a stepladder in terms of their placement in their product range. The RD 3500, RD 3510, RD 3600 and RD 3610 are all in a row of ascending features, ditto pricing. The RD 3610 is the highest and the priciest model amongst the quartet. Both the RD 3500 and RD 3510 are SIM-based phones and both of these have rather plain colours and finishes. The RD 3510, especially, has a very light-grey rear —

we feel this looks plain ugly. That being said both these phones are very compact and feel rather sturdy. The RD 3510 has a diaphragm type keypad instead of the button type keypads we're used to, and quite frankly this keypad is a let down in terms of key feedback; usability suffers as a result of this. Even the menu buttons are hard and feedback is not ideal. We also feel that this keypad will not last long, as our experience with diaphragm-based keypads over the years has taught us. Another ergonomic nightmare is the fact that neither of these phones — the RD 3510 and the RD 3500 — have a middle button on the joypad. Pressing the left menu button to select an option every time you wish to activate something within the menu is just a royal pain.

Despite the fact that the RD 3610 is the costliest of the quartet above, it's also got the cheapest build quality of all the phones and we didn't like its rough-finished rear. LG's RD 6100 is the fifth LG phone in this category. It's compact and well-built, with a choice of materials that is much better than the other LG phones. Once again it's a CDMA handset. The phone has a very solid in-hand feel. Although the joypad looks like it would be awkward to use at first glance, it surprisingly works beautifully. Once again this handset is SIM-based. A camera has also been provided; something the other LG handsets missed, complete with a mirror for vanity shots. Samsung's E1410 is the next phone in this category. It's a basic looking phone that has a solid build and feels very dense in-hand. No camera and no video playback support means that this is pretty Spartan for those looking for multimedia. That being said, the phone supports memory expansion via microSD. Samsung probably provided this feature for those wanting to store and listen to music. This was also the only phone in this category that featured Bluetooth, and is also the costliest phone in this category.

Nokia's 2626 was the only Nokia phone in this entire test. Nokia did send us a couple of other phones but these were priced well above our cut off point of Rs 8,000. The Nokia 2626 is a solid little phone that feels extremely well built owing to its compact dimensions and the choice of materials used on its outer body. There's no camera and no memory expansion, and with an internal memory of 2 MB it's clear that the 2626 isn't much more than a basic phone. At its price point we'd be surprised really, if it were to be anything more. You can get it in a plethora of colours though; the one we got was a bright postman red (eek!) that very few of us liked.

Performance

Amongst the GSM phones, Samsung's E1410 had the overall best performance. In fact we were impressed by the signal quality of this cellphone, as it has been our experience that ultra-affordable phones typically use ultra-cheap antennas. This wasn't the case here. We were disappointed with the Nokia 2626 in terms of in-call quality. The CDMA phones perform more or less similarly during the call and signal quality tests; the LG RD 3600 did have a very good quality headset provided and call quality with the hands-free plugged in was quite commendable. Only the LG RD 6100 had a camera but it wasn't too good; needless the inclusion of one is a feature that deserves mention in this particular price category.

And The Winner Is

LG's RD 3600 has the best value for money for amongst all the sub-Rs 4,000 cellphones and is our Digit Best Buy Winner in this category. It's suitable for someone looking at a CDMA phone that has terrific value for money — it's cheaper than its sibling the RD 3610 but manages to outdo it on both feature and performance tests — it's got a better keypad too. The best non-CDMA handset would be the Nokia 2626 — a little

brick that will last a long time and is quite a good phone in the bargain. If you absolutely must have a camera, you have only one option in this category, LG's RD 6100.

Cellphones above Rs 4000

The bridge between affordable and pricey

For those looking for a phone with a few more features than the shoestring options listed below we have these — the phones priced between Rs 4,000 and Rs 8,000. We feel this is perhaps the most interesting category of them all. The phones in this category may not have the appeal of costlier devices, nor do they move in the volumes that the sub-4000 rupee models do. But they do represent a good compromise between price and features. Chances are that anyone looking for a basic cellphone would at least demand some rudimentary features: a decent music player, the ability to take photos and videos, and of course an expandable memory capacity. It is also likely that such a user would also want a slightly better screen, with a greater viewable area and richer colours. Such phones will also be better built, offer (in general) better ergonomics and keypads. In short this category hits the sweet spot between functional and convergence. LG had four phones in this category; Samsung had three, while Sony Ericsson had two handsets.

Features

When it comes to looks its hard to ignore LG's KM380T — it has a very neat

looking flap that covers the keypad and opens downwards. In fact this reminds of us of some of the older Siemens and Motorola handsets and there's something about the whole flap setup that looks very classy. The sides of the phone are chrome and the back is finished in dark grey matte plastic. Overall it's quite a compact phone and is lightweight; this imparts a solid in-hand feel. The flap itself however isn't as well built as the rest of the phone and a little rough usage may get it damaged. The flap has a few buttons on its surface that coincide with the buttons that make up the joypad, and while the joypad works normally when the cover is open, close the cover and the same buttons work as multimedia controls. This phone has a 3.5-mm jack; you can plug in your headphones directly. While the joypad and menu buttons are quite usable and ergonomic, offering decent feedback, the number keypad is just too clicky and basically horribles. In fact

SMS junkies will rue the day they purchased this phone. Maybe people with extremely small fingers may find it decent; we certainly didn't. The keypad's lighting is very bright and visible, although it's not even. Samsung's L700 is a very simple looking phone but it's built like a brick. If there were ever a phone that could be used as a weapon this would be it — a solid, thick steel rear-battery cover and a front bezel also of solid steel. This makes the phone heavier and it's also quite a long device. This phone doesn't work without a SIM i.e. offline mode which is a shocking omission since the cheaper Samsung phones work fine.

Sony Ericsson's



Samsung L700